BUILD BOOK · FREESTANDING LOUNGE BAR + WET BAR ALCOVE REFRESH

The 8409 Bar

A six-foot slat-front bar in black and acacia for the basement game room, set in front of the blank wall at the foot of the stairs and facing the pool table, with the upstairs wet bar alcove converted into a matching service station. Designed from your photos and walkthrough videos to sit inside the house you already have: black steel, warm wood, cognac leather, brick, brass in small doses.

Status **Concept, pending measurements** Date **2026-11-08**

Build level **Weekend carpentry, circular saw + drill**

Location **Basement, blank wall by the stairs** Core materials ≈ **$1,700**

3D model **basement-walkthrough.html**

Reading the house

Every finished room in the house runs the same formula: a warm white shell, one heavy black element, one piece of warm organic wood, and a texture that carries the room (brick, leather, a geometric wallpaper). The dining table is the clearest statement of it: live-edge acacia split by a black river, on black steel. The media console repeats it in reverse: black box, round brass pulls. The powder room shows what the house does when it goes dark: near-black walls, fine geometric line, one warm light.

The bar should be the dining table's sibling, not a new idea. Black slatted body, acacia top, black pipe foot rail, brass only at the pulls and shelf brackets. The back wall behind it goes the powder-room route: deep espresso-black, so bottles and the guitars read like objects in a case.

Wall white

the shell



Console black

bar body, cabinet paint



Acacia

bar top, alcove top



Cognac

sectional, stool seats



Aged brass

pulls, brackets only



Brick

fireplace, stays as is



Espresso

back-bar wall, alcove niche

> THE POSITION
>
> Build one showpiece bar, downstairs, in front of the blank wall at the foot of the stairs where it overlooks the pool table. Turn the upstairs alcove into the service station (sink, ice, glass storage) rather than a second showpiece. Two display bars on two floors doubles the spend on the parts that actually cost money: the top and the hardware.

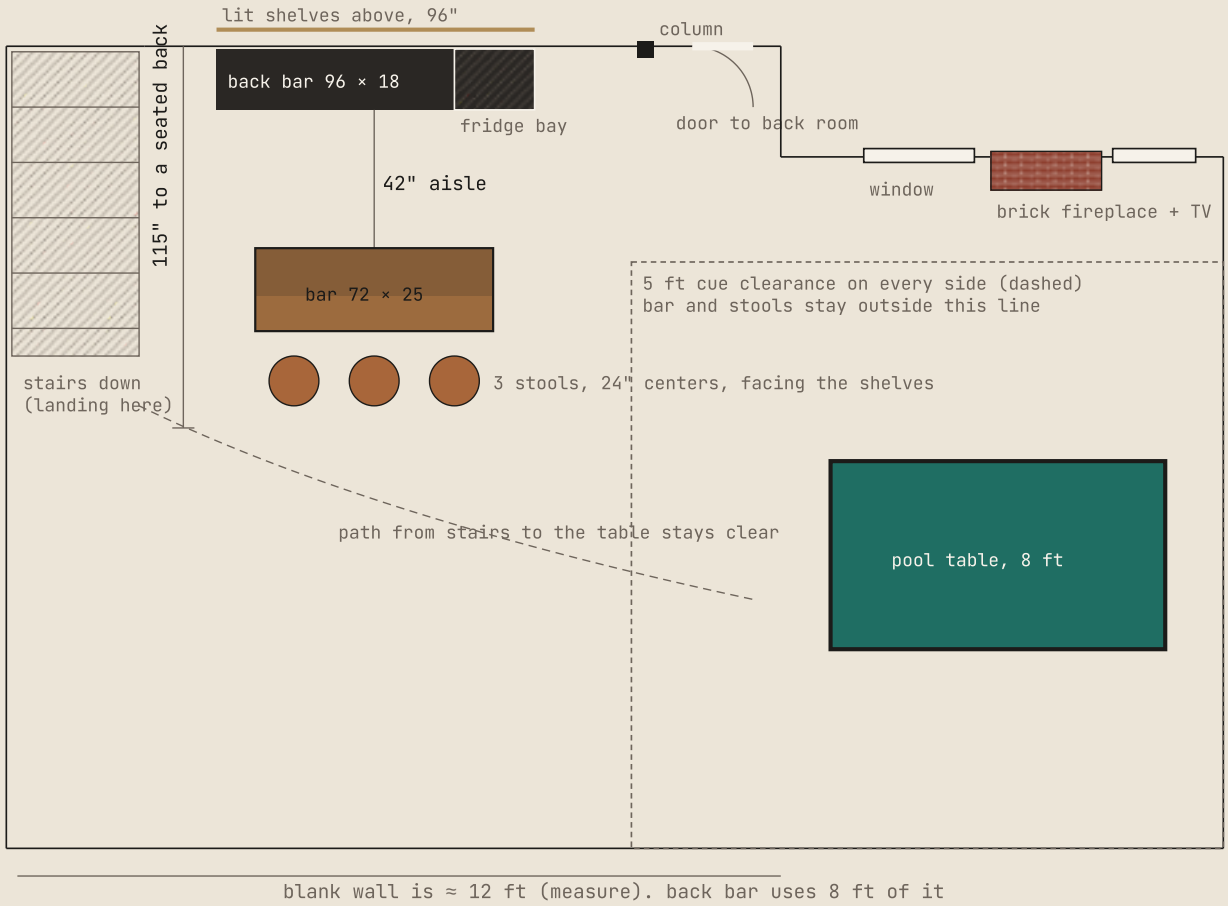
The counterargument, which is real: the alcove already has cabinetry and probably plumbing, so the cheapest way to "a sick bar" is to upgrade the alcove alone for about a quarter of this budget and skip the freestanding bar entirely. If money is the binding constraint this month, do that first and stop. The reason I still recommend the basement bar is that the basement is already a game room with nothing to anchor it: a pool table, a brick fireplace, a twelve-foot blank wall and a landing with no purpose. A bar is the one piece of furniture that makes that wall and that floor make sense, and a bar next to a pool table gets used in a way a bar in a front room never does. CONFIDENCE: MODERATE

Where it goes

The blank wall at the foot of the basement stairs is the back-bar wall. It is long, it is unbroken, and it sits under the dropped soffit with two recessed cans already in it, which is exactly where a lit shelf wall wants to be. The bar

sits parallel to that wall, 42 inches out, so one person works behind it with the fridge door open. Stools go on the open side. Seated guests face the shelves; the bartender faces the room and the pool table. The pool table keeps its five feet of cue clearance on every side, and the bar stays outside that line.

Two basement facts shape the design. The ceiling is low, roughly seven and a half feet under the soffit by the look of it, so the back bar stays horizontal: a low cabinet and two long shelves, no tall hutch. And basements hold humidity, so the slats are poplar rather than MDF, the plinth gets adjustable feet for a floor that is never dead flat, and nothing sits directly on the vinyl plank.



Plan, schematic. Room shape is read from three photos, so treat every distance as a placeholder. The one hard rule is the dashed line: a cue needs 58" from the rail, and the bar and its stools must sit outside it. From the blank wall the layout uses 115" of depth to the back of a seated guest, which the open landing appears to have with room to spare.

Walk through it first

The whole basement is modeled in a browser page you can walk around in, with the bar, back bar, pool table and cue clearance in place. Click the scene to look around, use W A S D to walk, or drag on a phone. Open the Dimensions panel, type in the real wall length and ceiling height, and the model rebuilds around them. The still frames below come from that model.

Open the 3D walkthrough



From the stairs. First thing you see coming down.



Seated at the bar. Eye height 58", shelves at 52" and 66".



Behind the bar. The bartender watches the game.



From the pool table. Cue clearance line on the floor.





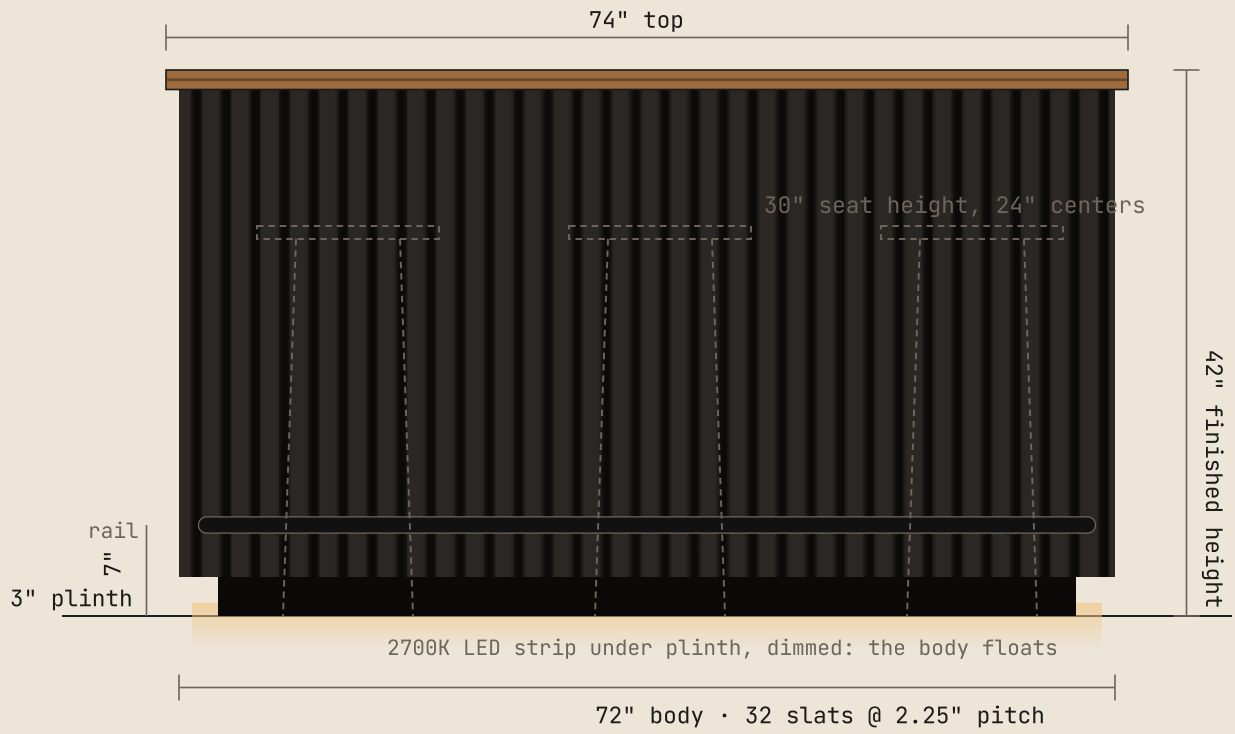
Back bar close. LED strip under each shelf. **Dollhouse.** Ceilings off, whole plan at once.

THE APPROACH, FROM THE TWEET

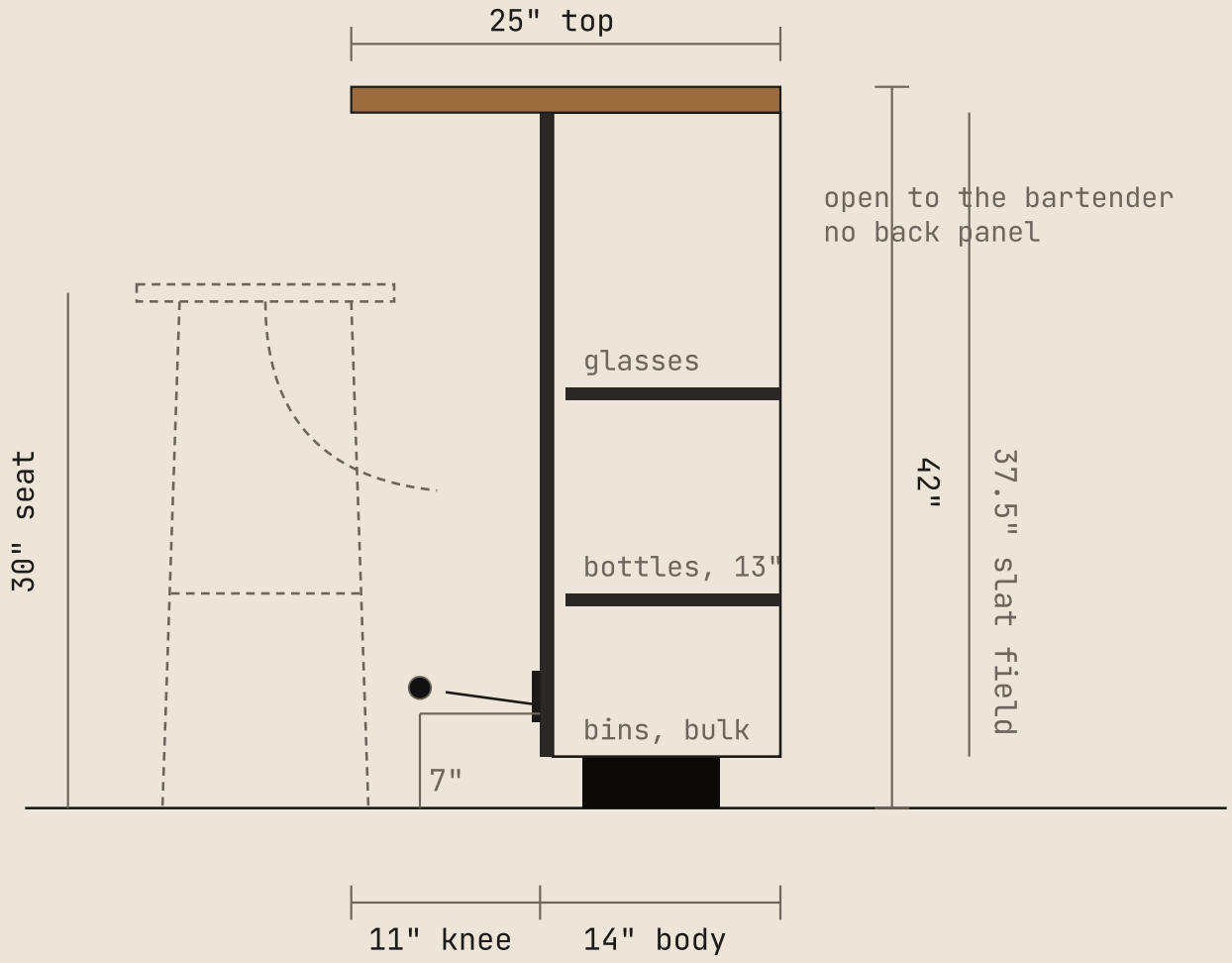
The post you sent (Pieter Levels, 7 Nov 2026) argues that a model like this can design furniture part by part, hand you a bill of materials, and let you order raw stock and assemble it yourself, skipping the brand markup that turns plywood and a slab into a four-figure retail bar. He puts the saving at about 85% against premium brands and points at Blender and FreeCAD as the free tools the model can drive. That is exactly the shape of this book: parts, dimensions, a cut list, a build order, a priced bill of materials, and now a 3D model to check it in. The one place I disagree with the framing is the percentage. Against a premium brand, 85% is plausible. Against a mid-market slat bar, this build saves 40 to 60%, and the saving is almost entirely labor and markup on the top and rail.

The bar

Standard bar ergonomics, nothing exotic: a 42" finished height, 25" of top with 11" hanging over the guest side for knees, a foot rail 7" off the floor, 30" stools. The body is a plywood box on a recessed plinth, faced with vertical 1.5" slats on a 0.75" gap. Painted one color, the gaps read as shadow lines and the whole thing goes quiet and expensive-looking. The acacia top is a stock butcher block, the same species as your dining table, oiled dark so the black river reads as family.



Front elevation, guest side. Scale 1" = 4 px. Slats are 1.5" wide with a 0.75" gap, so the 72" body takes exactly 32 slats. Foot rail is 1" black pipe on two floor flanges turned sideways onto the plinth face.



Section. Scale 1" = 4 px. The 14" body is shallow on purpose; a bar body deeper than 16" wastes floor and makes the bartender reach. Shelves at 12" and 24" give a 13" bottle bay and a glass bay. Plinth is recessed 3" on all four sides.

BODY

Two sheets of 3/4" plywood, pocket-screwed and glued. Front panel is one piece (72 × 37.5") so the slat field has no seams. Ends 13.25" deep so they tuck behind the front. One center divider, two shelves. Painted inside and out in the console black.

SLAT FACE

1.5" × 0.75" strips on a 0.75" gap, glued and 18-ga pinned to the painted front and ends. In a basement use 1 × 2 poplar, 22 eight-foot sticks, two slats per stick. MDF swells with humidity and telegraphs every edge through the paint. Rip MDF only if you run a dehumidifier year-round and the basement stays under 50% RH.

TOP

Stock acacia butcher block, 74 × 25 × 1.5". Sand to 180, one coat of a dark walnut oil stain to pull it toward the dining table, then a hardwax oil or Waterlox for spill resistance. Fix from below with figure-8 fasteners so it can move.

BASEMENT SPECIFICS

Adjustable leveling feet on the plinth (six, 3/8" thread), because basement slabs and the vinyl plank over them are never flat. Keep the plinth 3/4" off the floor on the feet so air moves under it. Seal every ply edge. Put the LED driver inside the body, not on the floor. If you do not already run a dehumidifier down there, budget one; it protects the acacia and the pool table felt alike.

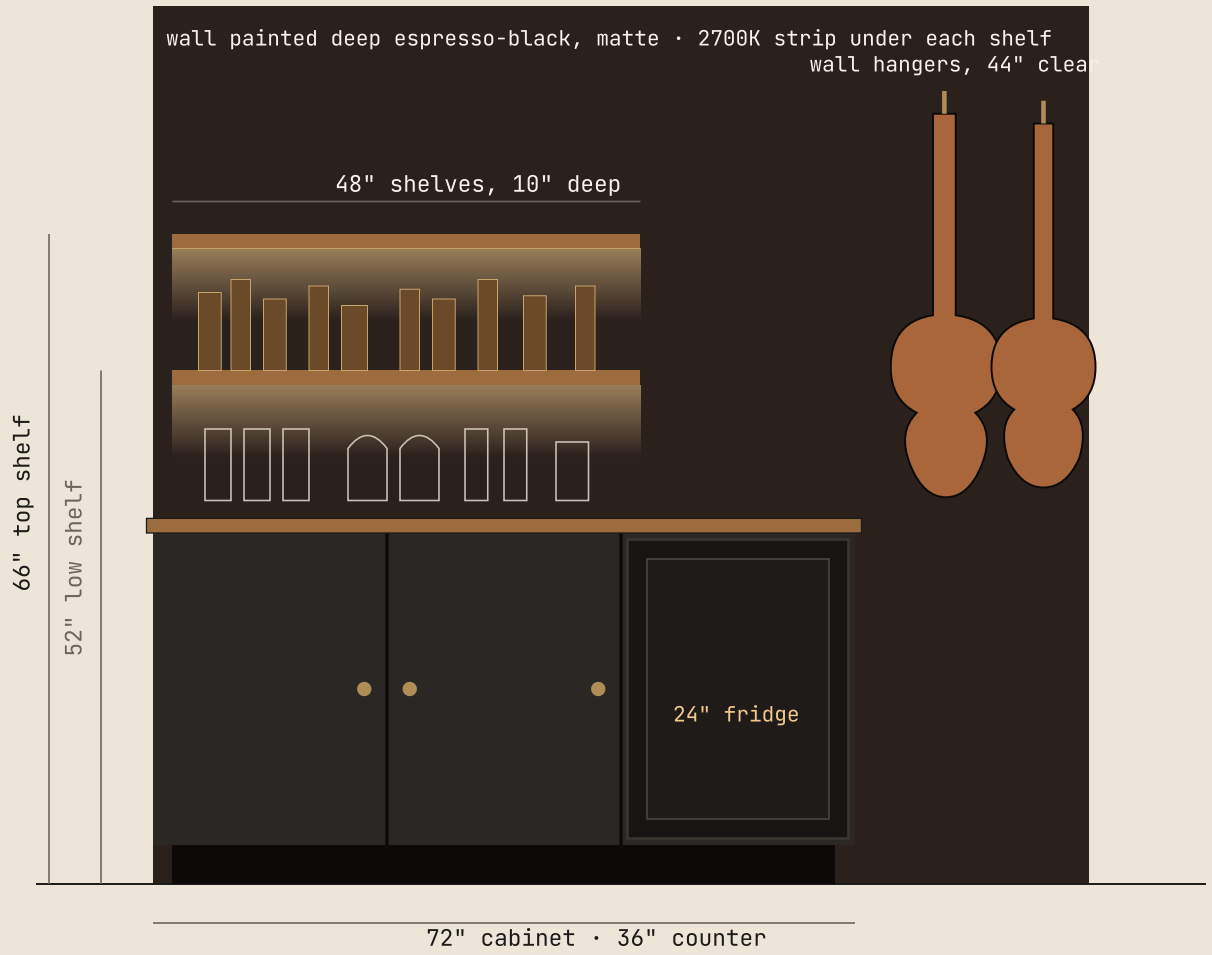
RAIL, LIGHT, HARDWARE

1" black iron pipe foot rail, 72" plus two 90° elbows and flanges, degreased and clear-coated. One 2700K COB LED strip under the plinth on a dimmer. Brass only on the back bar: round brass pulls that match the media console.

The back bar and the guitar wall

Paint the blank wall in the powder-room register: a deep espresso-black, matte, from the floor to the soffit. Against it, a 72" low cabinet at 36" with a beverage fridge in the right bay, two long floating shelves on the left, and the guitar that already lives down here (plus any others) hung vertically on the right where there is clear wall above the counter. Lit by the shelf strips, the guitars become the art instead of clutter on a stand. The wall is long enough that you can go to 96" of shelf if the budget allows; the drawing below shows the 72" version.

Upgrade path for later: run black poplar slats across the whole wall behind the shelves, floor to soffit. It is the same slat language as the bar and it is the single most photographed version of this idea. It costs about $350 in poplar and a long Saturday, so it is in the budget as an option, not a line.



Back bar elevation. Scale 1" = 3 px. Low cabinet is either two IKEA BESTÅ frames on a 2×4 plinth with an acacia offcut top, or a second slat box built the same way as the bar. Shelves are 2 × 10 stained to match the top, on hidden steel brackets rated 150 lb per shelf.

The wet bar alcove

From the walkthrough video, the alcove is the recessed niche you pass between the living room and the dining room: a white base cabinet with drawers below, a darker upper shelf or cabinet above. I could not see a sink

or faucet in the footage, so the drawings below assume there is a water line and a drain in the base cabinet. If there is not, nothing changes except the faucet line in the budget. CONFIDENCE: LOW ON THE EXISTING LAYOUT

The redesign keeps every expensive thing in place: the carcass, the plumbing, the electrical. It changes the five things that are visible. The result should look like the bar in the music room walked down the hall and parked itself in the wall.



As read from the video. White drawer base, dark upper, nothing lit. Dimensions are guesses.



After. Same box, same plumbing. Black enamel, brass knobs, acacia top, espresso niche, two lit shelves, a brass bar faucet if there is a sink.

SCOPE, IN ORDER

1. **Paint the base cabinet** in the same black cabinet enamel as the bar body. Degloss, bond primer, two coats. Doors and drawer fronts off and flat.
2. **Swap the pulls** for round brass knobs that match the media console, so the two black pieces in the living room speak the same language.

3. **New top** cut from a second 4 ft acacia block (the rest of that block becomes the back-bar shelves in the music room). Same stain and finish as the bar top. If there is a sink, template it before you cut.
4. **Paint the niche interior** walls and ceiling deep espresso-black, matte. Dark niche, lit shelves is the oldest trick in bar design and it costs a quart of paint.
5. **Replace the upper cabinet** with two floating shelves at 18" and 32" above the counter. If removing it exposes damage, keep the box, take the doors off, paint the interior black and shelve it.
6. **Light it** with a 2700K LED strip under each shelf on a plug-in dimmer, switched from the existing outlet.
7. **Faucet** in brushed brass or matte black, single-hole bar style, only if a sink exists.
8. **Optional**: a round brass-framed mirror at the back of the niche doubles the bottle glow. Skip if the niche is under 20" deep.

Cut list and hardware

Sized for a 72" bar. Every number here moves if your measurements say the bar should be 66" or 78", so treat this as the pattern, not the order. Plywood is 3/4" sanded (birch or maple face). Two sheets cover the body with a 10.5" × 96" strip left over for the divider and nailers.

PART	QTY	SIZE (IN)	STOCK	NOTES
Front panel (slat substrate)	1	72 × 37.5	3/4 ply, sheet 1	One piece, no seam behind the slats
End panels	2	13.25 × 37.5	3/4 ply, sheet 2	Butt behind the front; front overlaps ends
Bottom	1	70.5 × 13.25	3/4 ply, sheet 2	Sits on the plinth

PART	QTY	SIZE (IN)	STOCK	NOTES
Shelf	1	70.5 × 12	3/4 ply, sheet 2	At 24"; a second shelf at 12" if you want more bottle storage
Center divider	1	34 × 10.5	3/4 ply, sheet 1 offcut	Set back 2" from the front
Sub-top stretchers	2	72 × 4	3/4 ply, sheet 1 offcut	Front and back under the top; figure-8 fasteners into these
Plinth frame	1	66 × 8 outside	2 × 4, four 8-ft sticks	Recessed 3" all round; six leveling feet; LED strip on its outside face
Slats	44	1.5 × 0.75 × 37.5	1 × 2 poplar, 22 sticks of 8 ft	32 front + 6 per end. Pitch 2.25". Start and end each face with a full slat
Top	1	74 × 25 × 1.5	Acacia butcher block	1" overhang each end, 11" at the front
Foot rail	1	72 pipe + 2 elbows + 2 flanges	1" black iron pipe	Elbows turn into flanges screwed to the plinth face at 7" centerline
Back-bar shelves	2	48 × 9.25 × 1.5	2 × 10 stained, or acacia offcut	Hidden brackets, 2 per shelf, into studs
Alcove top	1	≈ 48 × 25 × 1.5	Acacia block, 4 ft	Template around sink if present

FASTENERS AND GLUE

Pocket screws 1-1/4" coarse (100), wood glue, 18-ga brad nails 1-1/4" for slats, construction adhesive for the plinth, 8 figure-8 top fasteners, 3" structural screws for the plinth to the body, six 3/8" leveling feet with T-nuts.

FINISH

Bond primer and black cabinet enamel in satin (one gallon covers bar, alcove cabinet and the low back-bar cabinet). Dark walnut oil stain, then hardwax oil or Waterlox on all acacia. Matte espresso-black wall paint, one gallon for the music room wall, one quart for the niche.

TOOLS YOU NEED

Circular saw with a straight-edge guide (or a track saw), drill driver, pocket-hole jig, brad nailer (borrow one; a $30 manual nailer also works for poplar slats), random orbit sander, 4 ft level, stud finder, clamps.

TOOLS THAT HELP

A table saw is not required for the poplar version; a miter saw or a circular saw with a stop block cuts 44 slats to length in an hour. A pipe clamp pair and a square make the carcass come out true.

Build sequence

Three weekends if you have the tools and a garage. Paint before assembly wherever possible; painting slats after they are on is the step that ruins the finish.

01

MEASURE AND MARK THE ROOM

Tape the bar and back bar footprints on the basement floor with painter's tape. Tape the 58" cue clearance around the pool table too and confirm the stools clear it. Sit a dining chair where the stools go. Walk the aisle with a fridge door open (24"). Adjust the bar length and the aisle now, before any wood is cut.

02

BREAK DOWN SHEETS AND RIP SLATS

Cut both plywood sheets to the list. Cut the poplar 1 × 2s to 37.5", two per stick. Lay the slats out on sawhorses and spray or roll them black first.

03

BUILD THE CARCASS

Pocket-screw ends and divider to the bottom, add stretchers, square it with a tape across the diagonals, then screw on the front panel. Build the 2 × 4 plinth as a separate frame and attach from inside the bottom with 3" screws so the LED strip wire has a path.

04

Paint the box

Prime and two coats of enamel inside and out. The front panel face must be fully black before slats go on because the gaps show it.

05

Hang the slats

Make a 0.75" spacer block. Start each face with a full slat flush at the corner, glue and pin every slat, spacer between. The ends get 6 slats each so the corners read as a solid wrap. Touch up pin holes with black filler.

06

Finish and fit the top

Sand the acacia to 180, stain, two coats of hardwax oil with a day between. Set it on the stretchers with figure-8 fasteners, 11" overhang to the guest side, 1" each end.

07

Rail and light

Degrease the black pipe with acetone, clear-coat it matte, assemble, and screw the flanges to the plinth face at a 7" centerline. Stick the LED strip to the plinth's outside face pointing down, run the driver inside the body to a cord on the bartender side.

08

Back bar

Paint the blank wall to the soffit. Find studs (or, on a furred basement wall, the furring strips), hang the two shelves level, mount the guitar hangers on the right at a height that puts the guitar bottoms 6" above the counter. Assemble the low cabinet, slide the fridge in, run its cord to the wall outlet. Put the two existing recessed cans on a dimmer.

09

Alcove

Same enamel, same knobs, same stain, same strips. Do it last, with the leftovers, so every finish matches because it is literally the same can.

Budget

Big-box retail at full price, no coupons, no Marketplace luck. Prices are from memory of recent ranges and should be checked at checkout; lumber and butcher block move the most. CONFIDENCE: MODERATE, ±15%

LINE	WHAT	LOW	HIGH
Bar body	2 sheets 3/4" sanded ply, 22 poplar 1 × 2s, four 2 × 4s, leveling feet	$300	$370
Bar top	Acacia butcher block 74 × 25 × 1.5	$230	$320
Foot rail	1" black pipe, elbows, flanges, clear coat	$60	$90
Paint	Bond primer + 1 gal cabinet enamel, 1 gal + 1 qt wall paint	$150	$200
Wood finish	Stain + hardwax oil or Waterlox for all acacia	$55	$90
Lighting	Two 2700K COB strips, drivers, dimmers	$60	$110
Fasteners	Pocket screws, brads, glue, figure-8s, filler	$45	$70
Back-bar cabinet	2 IKEA BESTÅ frames + doors, or a second slat box	$180	$280
Shelves and brackets	Two 2 × 10s or acacia offcut, 4 hidden brackets, guitar hangers	$90	$150
Second acacia block	4 ft × 25, for alcove top and shelves	$130	$190
Alcove hardware	Brass knobs, brackets, LED, one quart paint	$90	$150
Core build	**Everything above**	**$1,390**	**$2,020**
Stools	3 × black steel with tan leather seat; Marketplace first	$240	$480
Beverage fridge	24" undercounter, used	$150	$350
Bar faucet	Only if the alcove has a sink	$90	$160
Pocket-hole jig	Only if you do not own one	$45	$140
Full slat wall	Optional: poplar slats across the back wall, floor to soffit	$300	$400

LINE	WHAT	LOW	HIGH
Dehumidifier	Only if the basement does not already have one	$180	$260
All in	Core + every option	$2,395	$3,810

For comparison, a 6 ft slat-front bar with a hardwood top from a furniture retailer runs $1,800 to $3,500 for the bar alone with no back bar, no lighting, and a laminate or veneer top. The DIY version here puts the money into the two things you touch: the top and the rail.

WHERE TO CUT IF YOU MUST

- **Skip the back-bar cabinet** and use shelves only. Saves $180 to $280. The fridge then goes inside the bar body, which has room.
- **Rip the slats from MDF** instead of buying poplar. Saves about $100, but only if the basement is dehumidified year-round. Otherwise it is a false saving.
- **Use a 2 × 12 glue-up** for the top instead of acacia, stained to match. Saves $150, looks 80% as good, and your dining table will make the difference obvious.
- **Do the alcove alone first.** Roughly $350 to $500 with the second acacia block, and it is a one-weekend job.

WHAT I NEED TO LOCK THE DRAWINGS

Six measurements and two photos

- Basement: length of the blank wall, ceiling height under the soffit and under the main ceiling, and the distance from the blank wall to the pool table rail.
- Where the outlets are on or near the blank wall, and whether there is a floor drain or water line anywhere nearby (a basement sink changes the plan).
- Alcove upstairs: opening width, height, niche depth, base cabinet height. Straight-on daylight photo with the lights on. Is there a sink?
- How many seated: 2 or 3? It sets the length at 60" or 72".

- Do you run a dehumidifier down there, and do you own or can you borrow a brad nailer and a miter saw?